

Chapter 15

Micro, Macro, Choice, and Structure

Nancy Folbre

My primary network is political economy, not sociology. If, as network theory suggests, I am who I know, I am also who I write about, and therefore have become someone new in the course of writing these comments. Still, the socialist/feminist/economist I started out as prevails. In commenting briefly on each of the essays, I have selfishly (or perhaps only self-interestedly) assessed their relationship to my own theoretical concerns. I believe that feminist theorists must develop better links between their conceptualization of individual agency (what economists term a micro foundation) and its theory of macro structures. And I believe that macro structures can't be reduced to one dimension of gender inequality. Three of these essays, it seems to me, are particularly relevant to the former, three to the latter. I've organized my discussion of them around a larger effort to clarify this micro/macro issue. I've paused in the middle, and at the end, to indulge my own priorities.

How do we interpret the choices of individual men and women and how they differ? Christine Williams espouses a Chodorowian psycho-analytic approach, arguing that the organization of child rearing creates a gendered distribution of preferences and priorities in the next generation. Lynn Smith-Lovin and J. Miller McPherson develop a network approach, arguing that preferences are determined by the "relations in which an individual is embedded." Debra Friedman and Carol Diem, on the other hand, defend the economists' traditional emphasis on rational choice. These approaches are not mutually exclusive: The family could be conceptualized as the first "network" that affects subsequent involvements. Once their preferences are set by childhood experiences and social networks, individuals may proceed to act as rational maximizers. The specifics of these arguments, however, are not so easily reconciled.

Williams provides a cogent defense of feminist object relations theory, summarizing much recent research pro and con. I appreciate her discus-

sion of Parson's early appropriation of Freud, and Chodorow's feminist reappropriation. I am convinced by her most general point, that psychoanalytic theory can complement analysis of forms of discrimination embedded in social institutions. And I agree that many positivist critiques of psychoanalytic theory are unfair. But object relations theorists often seem reluctant to risk specific claims—the generalities they invoke are not even contestable.

Williams often equates the broad argument that men and women have disparate ways of relating to the world with the more specific claim that the disparity can be attributed to the organization of child rearing. The work of Lillian Rubin and Evelyn Fox Keller (discussed by Williams) strongly supports the former, but not necessarily the latter. Similarly, Williams's description of her own research dwells on the devaluation of femininity by male nurses, without discussing the childhood experiences of the individuals involved. I wish she had speculated more on the ways we might explore the relative influence of mother rearing (the factor emphasized by Chodorow) and cultural norms, transmitted through reinforcement or cognitive learning.

Also, the possible role of biological factors is slighted by the suggestion that this inevitably implies "determinism"—a word feminist social scientists often seem to brandish like garlic to keep vampire sociobiologists at bay. I mean this as self-criticism, as much as commentary on Williams's arguments—all of us should try to be less territorial. Biological differences between men and women may shape the social construction of gender identity—the tendency to rule them a priori out of order is antithetical to the ideals of interdisciplinary research.

Similar concerns surfaced as I read the essay by Lynn Smith-Lovin and J. Miller McPherson, which focused rather narrowly on the precepts of network theory. I kept wanting to ask the authors what alternative theoretical perspectives might predict the same results. They contrast their assumptions with those of neoclassical economic theory, but not those of object relations theory. In the network view, preferences are not exogenously given, as generally assumed by neoclassical economists, but "determined by the relations in which a person is embedded." I agree, parting company with most of my fellow economists. But could some relationships (such as those with parents) be more important than others? Aren't individuals more than the sum of their network nodes? If neoclassical economic theory overstates the role of individual choice, this theory seems to eliminate it.

Many of the descriptive tools of network analysis are interesting, and the vocabulary is a lot of fun. I now realize that I'm prone to homophily, but involved in at least one intransitive sentiment relation. Pillow talk

aside, there are some important insights here—especially the notion that very small differences in the size and character of a network can have a cumulative and therefore quite significant effect on the flow of information over the life cycle. However, as the authors themselves emphasize, network theory puts more emphasis on measurement than explanation, and leaves many questions unanswered. Why are women more prone to homophily than men? Why are women less tolerant of intransitivities? Would Smith-Lovin and McPherson be willing to splice in some object relations theory here? Or some biology? Or could these patterns represent rational responses to constraints imposed on women's roles, constraints that do not all flow from network locations?

Debra Friedman and Carol Diem do a good job of arguing the latter. As an economist, I applaud their eloquent defense of rational choice. However, they exaggerate a bit when they assert that feminist scholars "have typically assumed that rational-choice theory is a fundamentally sexist theory." That statement slights the work of those who have sought to reinterpret the meaning of rational choice, to modify orthodox conceptualizations by suggesting that information is imperfect, preferences are partially endogenous, and utilities are partially interdependent (England 1989; McCrate 1988; Folbre 1988). I love the rational baby, but want to throw out the reductionist bathwater. And I want economists to admit that even grown-up Rational Economic Man succumbs to temper tantrums.

The strongest point of the Friedman/Diem essay, it seems to me, is its distinction between effective and ineffective choices. They argue that individuals may avoid certain commitments to collective action, not because they selfishly want to free ride, but because they judge them ineffective. It is rational and efficient for individuals to ask not only, Is this the right thing to do? but also, Will it make a difference? Still, I think Friedman and Diem understate the extent to which the game-theoretic dilemma, what economists call "the coordination problem," is affected by the level and persistence of altruism. A person who makes a commitment on a purely moral basis, irrespective of the consequences, reduces uncertainty for other decision-makers, and makes it more likely that their commitments will be effective. Whether you call it altruism, leadership, or just plain old strength of character, it's usually an important catalyst to more instrumental forms of collective action.

Friedman and Diem are correct to emphasize that rational-choice theory begins with the assumption that individuals are self-interested, not selfish. Individuals are assumed to maximize utility, not wealth, and they may gain utility from others' happiness as well as their own. Hence the possibility of altruism. However, the theory is seldom applied, at

least by neoclassical economists, without the related, very convenient assumption that there are no interdependent utilities. This latter assumption means that your utility does not affect mine, and thus does imply complete selfishness. Indeed, suspension of this assumption would wreak havoc in introductory microeconomics classes, where students are asked to prove that demand curves slope downward. If, for instance, the consumer's invisible utility function encompassed the welfare of Central American peasants, he or she might buy more cups of coffee, rather than less, when their price increased.

Rational economic man isn't what he used to be, having been beaten about the head by economists, as well as sociologists. John Elster (1979), Geoffrey Hodgson (1988), and Robert Frank (1990), to name a few, have demonstrated the complexity—and occasional irrationality—of what we call *rational behavior*. Similarly, game theorists like Robert Axelrod (1984) and rational-choice sociologists like Michael Hechter (1987; Hechter, Opp, and Wippler 1990) have begun to develop plausible stories about the evolution of cultural norms and institutions as solutions to coordination problems. In my opinion, these *institutionalist* approaches offer a more constructive microeconomic foundation than neoclassical theory—one that is actually more consistent with Friedman and Diem's larger agenda.

Rather than "choosing" between individual rationality and cultural/social determination, we should move beyond this traditional dichotomy to ask how preferences are socially constructed, and why individuals sometimes actively choose a set of "metapreferences" (preferences about preferences, such as What should I want? and What would I like to enjoy?). Such questions are inherently less tractable than those which begin with a fixed assumption that tastes and preferences are exogenously given, or that individual choice is irrelevant. The possible answers are less predictable, less certain, but far more relevant to our understanding of reality.

The appropriate metaphor is a strategic game in which the rules and rewards themselves are subject to negotiation, a game with both cooperative and noncooperative aspects. In traditional neoclassical economic theory, individuals merely choose to buy or sell, subject to income and prices. They have perfect information, and the consequences of their choice are clear; given perfect competition, the parameters are unaffected by others' decisions. In a *game-theoretic* world, choices are much more difficult, because they are strategic. Outcomes hinge on the simultaneous decisions of other participants.

Decisions to buy or sell are far less important than decisions to accept or contest cultural norms, to reinforce or weaken certain social institutions, to free ride or to pay up. Family, gender, race, ethnicity, citizen-

ship, class, all represent vectors of collective identity and action that can empower certain individuals more than others, often in contradictory ways. Formal mathematical models offer only limited insights, because the game can't be reduced to the simple question, Who wins? What does it mean to win? Does the winner define it, or the other way around? The contest takes place on a microlevel, but its rules, outcomes, and rewards are defined on a macrolevel.

The macrolevel is the locus of what we social scientists tend to describe as "structures" of inequality. Yet we are a long way away from any comprehensive, even consistent theory of such structures. In my opinion, Beth Anne Shelton and Ben Agger are grossly overconfident of Marxist theory. On the other hand, the essay by Dana Dunn, Elizabeth Almquist, and Janet Chafetz on macrostructural perspectives seems too atheoretical and empiricist, almost taxonomic in its approach. I feel more affinity with Kathryn Ward's criticisms of world systems theory, but it doesn't quite deliver on its promise of "reconceptualization."

I have great respect for the Marxist tradition, which has informed my own work. It angers me to see it simplified and distorted. Shelton and Agger endorse a naive epistemology akin to the very positivism they criticize when they write "a theory's validity is proven by the extent to which it is successful in changing the world, not in terms of whether data support the hypotheses derived from the theory." If Hitler had won World War II would that have validated his theories? If the former Soviet Union becomes a capitalist state (if it has not already) will that invalidate Marx? No, and that's not what Marx and Engels meant when they wrote, in their *Theses on Feuerbach*, that the point was not to understand the world, but to change it. There's a big difference between statement of purpose and the assertion that there is some simple arbiter of truth.

These authors assert that Marxism and feminism are not fundamentally different or opposed traditions, that they have "a common enemy." However, they never explain exactly what this common enemy is. The ruling class? Capitalism? All systems of domination? All those who are privileged by systems of domination? Isn't it possible that the correct definition of "the enemy" depends on which struggles are being fought where by whom? Other scholars have developed stronger (though, to my mind, still unpersuasive) arguments in feminist defense of Marxism. Lise Vogel, for instance, argues that male domination is functional for the social reproduction of capitalism (1983). Fraad, Resnick, and Wolff develop the very different argument that men exploit women through a "feudal" class process (1989).

Feminist strands strengthened the fabric of the early Marxist tradition, particularly in the writings of Friedrich Engels and August Bebel. Similar

strands traversed early neoclassical theory via Jeremy Bentham, Harriet Taylor, and John Stuart Mill (Folbre and Hartmann 1988). The distinct feminist approach that began to emerge in the late nineteenth century wove many of these strands together in a distinct cloth, emphasizing the collective interests of men and women across classes, conflicts among family members, and the importance of household production. Feminist theory cannot simply be reduced to or subsumed within Marxist theory, especially by pronouncements such as Shelton and Agger's that "Marxism is the more global and more agile analytical strategy because it offers a perspective on the interrelatedness of the totality."

Ironically, the essay by Dana Dunn, Elizabeth Almquist, and Janet Chafetz makes me appreciate the force of Marxist theory on my own thinking. They start out asking "Who gets what? And why?" but focus exclusively on gender, hardly alluding to other dimensions of inequality, such as nation, race, or class. They miss what seems to me the most vital aspect of a macrostructural perspective—the conflicts and complementarities between different structures of inequality that reflect contradictory collective interests. Class differences divide women, just as gender differences divide classes. To take just one example, in countries where a large percentage of women work as domestic servants, a large percentage of affluent women are freed from more onerous requirements of housework and child care.

This essay provides a very useful review of the sociological and anthropological literature on gender stratification, and it gracefully acknowledges the unresolved differences between the materialist approaches represented by Blumberg and Chafetz and the culturalist approach represented by Sanday. Reading along, however, I get the uneasy feeling that feminists have become the establishment, citing authoritative tomes ("the following all argue that . . .") rather than questioning authority. Sometimes the intent seems to find correlations, rather than to provide explanations. Terms like *predictors* and *indicators* make me nervous because they seem to privilege facts that can be quantified, aggregated, and compared "panhistorically and cross-culturally."

These "facts" are all culturally constructed, and many are emblematic of gender bias. Labor force participation rates are notoriously inaccurate, because they underestimate women's participation in the market through family enterprises and informal work. They implicitly devalue nonmarket work as "nonparticipation." Marriage rates mean something quite different in a polygamous than in a monogamous culture. The proportion of women in manufacturing, like the proportion of men, reflects patterns related to the timing and pace of economic development, not merely gender dynamics. Not that such "indicators" are

entirely spurious—rather that their interpretation, outside any historical context, as "major independent variables" is macroempiricist, not macrostructural.

Some of Kathryn Ward's earlier work (1984), focused on aggregate measures of fertility and integration into the world system, falls into the same category, simply defining a different set of major independent variables. In her essay in this volume, however, Ward promotes a more convincing historical perspective, calling for more attention to race and class and more exploration of dynamics between men and women inside the household. As she points out, Immanuel Wallerstein and those of his school have simply subsumed women within households whose fate has been largely determined by the requirements of the global capitalist economy.

Her criticisms of the world system approach are well taken, though I would take them even further. As she points out, exclusive emphasis on relations of exchange and market labor obscures the importance of child rearing and household work. In their emphasis on European capitalist hegemony, world systems theorists overlook the influence that indigenous structures of governance exert over forms of articulation with the world market. No collective interests, coalitions, or political struggles within peripheral nations are theorized, so it's hardly surprising that patriarchal interests and institutions remain invisible. Ward correctly points to the "persistent presence of precapitalist forms of informal and household labor" and argues that men have actively sought to perpetuate the traditional sexual division of labor. She cites research that substantiates this point, such as Jean Pyle's (1990) case study of Irish government policies that effectively restricted female labor force participation.

How then to reconstruct the theory? Ward's recommendations are right on. We can't just add women and stir. Yes, gender, race, and class need to be analyzed in a holistic manner. Yes, we need to look at overlapping relations of production and the distribution of resources. But we need to go beyond these exhortations to develop a conceptual vocabulary that can clarify the relations between different dimensions of collective identity and action. We need to talk more about systems, modes, structures. We need to move beyond critique.

A lot of possible paths are open; I'm not sure I'm headed in the right direction or that I'm carrying the right tools. One thing I like about the Marxist tradition is its emphasis on forms of collective identity and action. This needs to be extended to nation, race, gender, family, and class. This implies that most individuals are in contradictory positions—privileged as men, but exploited as workers, exploited as women, but privileged as citizens of the

United States. Complicated, but, I think, accurate because it helps explain why individuals often join coalitions that are inimical to some of their interests (feminist Republicans, for instance).

One thing I don't like about the Marxist tradition is its economism, reflected in a tendency to reduce social structures to relations of production or distribution. I think social institutions, including implicit and explicit rules, laws, and cultural norms, set the stage and define the context for both production and distribution. In my work, I describe these as structures of constraint that reflect the interests and power of shifting coalitions (Folbre 1991). No balanced pluralism is implied, rather a picture in which patriarchal, capitalist, and white U.S. citizens' interests often converge in oppressive cultural and political, as well as economic hegemony. My intent is strategic—to study the potential for realignments that might empower the groups with which I identify. Structures of constraint define the context of individual choice; they shape individual tastes and preferences, self-images and affections, networks, affinities, and commitments. But the microlevel is not pre-terminated. Individuals are still free to exercise their developing capacities for rational action, free to devise new strategies of conflict and cooperation, free to choose. The best choice, in my opinion, is commitment to a feminist theory that is based on principles broader than gender justice alone.

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NEITHER BIOLOGY NOR SOCIAL LEARNING: REPLY TO FOLBRE

Christine L. Williams

Folbre raises three criticisms of psychoanalysis in "Micro, Macro, Choice, and Structure." First, she is concerned that the possible influence of biology on our gender arrangements is ignored by the theory. Ironically, it was Freud who popularized the "anatomy is destiny" slogan, and he based his theory of "penis envy" on innate differences between the sexes. Feminist versions of psychoanalytic theory reject this simple biological determinism. Although feminist psychoanalytic theorists do carefully consider the influence of the mother-child relationship on the social organization of gender, they view this essentially biological bond as mediated by culture, personality, and social structure. Our gendered identities are not guaranteed outcomes of our biological natures.

The second concern Folbre raises is that the generalizations drawn from psychoanalytic theory are not "contestable," that is, no one can disagree with them. In fact, several sociologists dispute Chodorow's claims, including her assertion that women have greater emotional needs for connection and more developed relational capacities than men (e.g., Risman 1987; Epstein 1988; Molm in this volume, Ridgeway this volume, Smith-Lovin's reply to Molm in this volume). In my opinion, the evidence supports Chodorow's claims, but not everyone agrees with me!